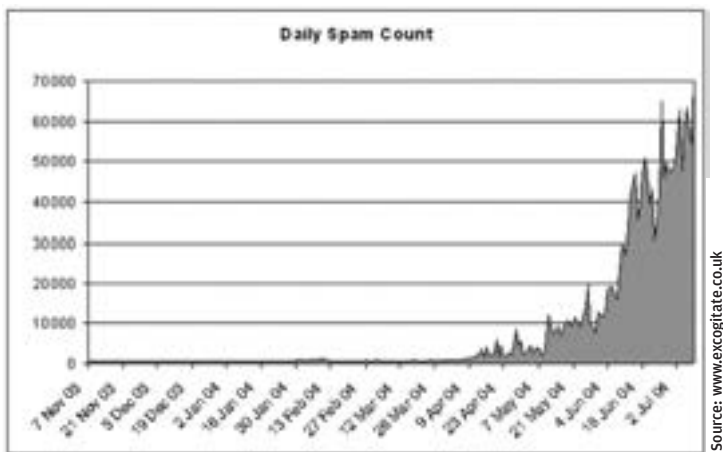


sent to a recipient without his or her consent. These mails also use a lot of tricks to hoodwink your spam filter.



The graph shows the exponential increase in spam from November 2003

So how do these spammers obtain your e-mail addresses? There are various tools that can be used to harvest e-mail addresses. Some of the most common ones are using a spider or a 'bot' to crawl the Web and collect e-mail ids. These Web spiders go around looking for e-mail addresses all over the Web. The most common targets are sites where you give out your e-mail address for purposes of registration, or a Web site where you put up your mail id so that other members of that site/group can contact you. It is, however, possible to fool the Web spider by substituting the '@' symbol with 'at' or any such other symbol while posting an e-mail ID. For example, instead of posting your e-mail address as `abc@xyz.com`, you could try `abc(at)xyz(dot)com`. Spammers also use techniques such as a dictionary attack, where they guess common names at known domains.

These so-called "spambots" are a major producer of e-mail spam. Some of the worst spammers create e-mail viruses that transform an unprotected PC into a "zombie computer"; this